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QUESTION:

“Songs are the highest form of poetry.” Using this assertion as your point of reference, provide a critical exegesis of how the song, *‘Kutonga Kwaro’* (2017) by Jah Prayzah as the highest form of poetry, provides a political retrocast and a forecast on Zimbabwean politics using the concept of *‘Musha’*.

A poem is only fruitful when it turns out to be melodious, the alignment of lyrics and tune combined. Political ideas are conveyed in patterns that make information and events memorable, repeatable and therefore readily applicable to life. This is clearly depicted by the song, *Kutonga Kwaro* (Thy reigns) 2017 by Mukudzei Mukombe popularly known as Jah Prayzah, which (*Kutonga Kwaro*) reveals Zimbabwe's bloodless coup, which took place in mid-November and brought to an end the 37-year rule of Robert Mugabe, certainly had its political casualties. With an uncertain future ahead the artist Jah Prayzah, appears to be benefitting from a serendipitous album release, seen by some as prophetic of the dramatic November change. Due to the usage of vivacious poetic devices by the persona (Soldier), the essay below will review how the poem delivers a political retrocast and a forecast on Zimbabwean politics by the alignment of the '*Musha*' concept.

First and foremost, Jah Prayzah, born Mukudzei Mukombe on July 4, 1987, has seen his popularity spike as never before in the wake of Emmerson Mnangagwa's ascendance to the presidency. Prayzah's fans describe '*Kutonga Kwaro*' as prophetic (Forecast), as if the singer knew that the military, whose uniform he performs in, would imminently intervene in Zimbabwe's political affairs. Everyone, from the elderly to kindergartners, can be heard in the streets singing songs from *Kutonga Kwaro*, the album Prayzah released on the 13th of October 2017, almost exactly one month prior to Mugabe's ouster. Right from the nomenclature (etymology) *Kutonga Kwaro*, the accumulation of the infinitive verb *Kutonga* meaning having sovereign power, and *Kwaro* is a possessive with a secondary prefix *kwa-* aiming at enlarging or amplifying something. The expression is simply revealing Emmerson Mnangagwa's dominance to the presidency. Kahari (1994:21) articulated that, 'Man is name, name is man...as a measure of the importance I attach to names and characterisation, and to their ideological implications.' There is power in the spoken word (Nommoic creativity).

More so, by the continuation of a syntactic unit from one line of verse into the next line without a pause (enjambment), for instance in the first two lines, the persona (a soldier) is entering a particular familiar habited dwelling place. The poet utters,

'Haa woo ti

Tisvikewo pano '

From the above morally used phrase '*Tisvikewo pano*' among the Shona society is referring to a persona (soldier) who is a caricature of the current president Emmerson Mnangagwa popularly known as '*Garwe*' (Lacoste) post to his abandonment from the ruling Zimbabwe

African National Union – Patriotic Front (Zanu-PF) party. He is arriving at a place where he was going to remove the owner and insert himself as the possessor of the homestead in a form of a coup. By the usage of ‘*Musha*’ concept the persona (Jah Prayzah) is linking the whole poem with the local Shona cultural norms. Asante (1998:7) posits out that, ‘Afrocentricity is the relocation or repositioning of Africans in a place of agency in which they are no longer spectators but take an active part in self-determination.’ The November military action was definitely a palace coup, in that it sought to replace a leader with another member of the elite, namely expelled Vice-President Emmerson Dambudzo Mnangagwa who had the support of the military.

Moreover, the lyricist or poet uses a cultural or totemic allusion ‘*Mwendamberi*’ (The one who focuses) by which he (Soldier or *Mwendamberi*) is going to insert new laws and he is not going to relinquish or give up. The persona declares,

‘Ndini Mwendamberi

Ndaakuchinja mutemo

...

...

Nyangwe huku dzamawundura

Ndaakuchinja mutemo’

‘I am the one who focuses, I am now changing the law... even the chickens that you have dressed, I am now changing the law’

From the quotation above, the guest (Mnangagwa) who is a soldier is revolutionary. The November 2017 “Operation Restore Legacy” military action in Zimbabwe, highlight a state that was going through a social and economic crisis in addition to political uncertainty. These were fertile grounds for elite infighting within the ruling Zanu-PF party where military intervention which was revolutionary, unwittingly led to the end of the 37 years of the Robert Mugabe presidency, the extinction of other securocracy and G-40 members from the aristocracy (ruling government), something which democratic elections and protest have failed to do. According to Fanon (1967:134) ‘Post-independent Africa is plagued by a serious crisis of leadership to the extent that instead of everything being added unto the people it

seems all things are being subtracted from the people.’ A military coup was widely welcomed as a small but significant step towards a better and more democratic Zimbabwe.

Furthermore, the poet uses a stabiliser ‘–wo’ in ‘*Zaruraiwo dura*’ (Open thy granary) simply to reveal that the guest (soldier) will abundantly satisfy the households with sufficient food and by personifying ‘*ngoma*’ (Drums) by using the word ‘*Dzasvika*’ (It has arrived) and ‘*Woye mambo*’ (Ooh lord) an expression mainly used by Shona people to convey their joy, simply mean that, it will be celebrated or eulogised by the whole community. The former owner of the place is not able to nurture his ethnic people. The Lyricist sates that, (in the patois Shona language):

‘Zaruraiwo dura

Dzasvika rova ngoma

...

Woye mambo’

‘Open thy granary, it has arrived hit the drum...ooh lord’

From the above lyrical verse, the upcoming leader (Mnangagwa) is supposed to transform the economic hardship into pleasurable and stable economy which is the failure of mainstream opposition (ZANU-PF) to develop alternative pro-poor economic policies which proceeds since the 2008 national-economic crisis. According to wa Thiongo (1983:76), ‘Some saw the party as a collaborator with apartheid government because of the acceptance of a leadership role by its leader in institutions created by the apartheid regime. Yet there were those nationalists who embraced class struggle and economic liberation’

Additionally, by the use of a hyperbolic expression ‘*Rinofadza nenherera*’ (He makes the orphans happy). The guest (Soldier) will be able to take care of everyone at the homestead with whom he has arrived. Indeed, some of the lyrics in its ‘*Kutonga Kwaro*’ title track seem to be praising the military for seizing control. Prayzah laments, in the vernacular Shona language:

‘Rinofadza nenherera (Gamba)

Gamba ramakajaira (Gamba)’

‘Behold, I am here, the soldier is ruling, he makes the orphans happy...’

From the above lyrics, under Mugabe’s rule, fellow Zimbabweans were depicted as orphans, without a guardian who cares for them. Prayzah is revealing a change from the former president’s tyrannical or despotic rule to a rule characterised by egalitarianism. According to Fanon (1963:165), the setting up of a one party state, ‘jostling and bullying people, rousing anxiety instead of reassuring the nation and intimating to the general population that they are in continual danger’. The November 2017 military action, no matter how it would play out to the end, will continue to be an interesting reference to the necessity of balancing demands for human rights, constitutionalism and democracy with an open-minded understanding of political reality.

Still in the same vein, the persona uses repetition of the expression ‘*Kutonga Kwaro (Gamba)*’ (Thy reigns, [The Hero]) in the chorus and parallelism. The repeated use of the same word or word pattern as a rhetorical device by the guest (Soldier) simply mean he is eulogising his reign on a particular homestead. This is also witnessed by the way the poet Prayzah is raising voice gradually at that certain stanza in the chorus. Shona language is largely prosodic, meaning is derived from tone. The persona utters in the Shona dialect,

‘Ngoma kwainorira (Gamba)

Ngoma yamakajaira (Gamba

...

Kutonga kwaro (Gamba)

Kutonga kwaro (Gamba)

...

...

Kutonga kwaro (Gamba)’

‘Where drums played, the drums you were used to...Thy reigns (The hero)...Thy reigns (The hero)’

From the above quotation, Mnangagwa was named by Zimbabwe's ruling Zanu-PF party as successor to Mugabe following Mugabe's forced removal by the country's military. The celebration is witnessed by Mnangagwa’s arrival at the venue where the inauguration took

place where a massive convoy of cars made up of Lacoste supporters playing Prayzah's song '*Kutonga Kwaro*' (Thy reigns) in their vehicles and even the incident. This simply reveals that Mnangagwa's reign was celebrated by everyone. According to Freire (1980:193), 'The struggle for this liberation must therefore be carried out by the oppressed to restore the humanity of both the oppressors and the oppressed.'

In addition, by the diction '*Pamusoroi...*' (Excuse me...) as it used in verse 2 in a repetitive manner simply reveals that the guest is taking over as the head of the house in a polite way without embarrassing the former owner of the house. The lexicon '*Pamusoroi...*' (Excuse me) is intended by the guest (Soldier) to serve as a reason, cause or justification of his adventure. The persona (Prayzah) articulated that,

'Pamusoroi mambo

...

Pamusoroi mambo

...

Pamusoroi mambo'

'Excuse me lord...Excuse me lord...'

It is clear from the above assertion from the poem '*Kutonga Kwaro*' (Thy reigns), the persona is revealing the manner in which the Lacoste (Mnangagwa) takes over power from Mugabe's dictatorial leadership. Zimbabwe's bloodless coup, which took place in mid-November and brought to an end the 37-year rule of Robert Mugabe was a harmless march. Ranger (1985:78) states that, 'Africans are demanding for better living conditions for the multitude whose condition is largely blamed for leadership.' On 18 November, thousands of Zimbabweans took to the street in a solidarity march with the Zimbabwe Defence Forces (ZDF). The Zimbabwe Defence Forces (ZDF) military action was code-named "Operation Restore Legacy" and resulted in the eventual resignation of President Robert Gabriel Mugabe and the nomination of former Vice President Emmerson Dambudzo Mnangagwa as Mugabe's successor.

To add on, the poet repeated the same vowel –a in a form of a rhyme in six succeeding lines. This clearly shows that, people will particularly pay attention to the formerly forbidden guest (Soldiers) which has arrived at their homestead. By the diction '*Motyora muzura*' (Bowing

down) reveals respect to the upcoming guest and that act is mainly common among the Shona society. Everyone will be loyal including the former owner of the homestead. The persona (Jah Prayzah) emits,

‘...motyora muzura

...rinotonga musha

...rinosiya radhindha

...

...

Jerusarema kutamba kwavaZumba’

...you will bow down...it will reign...left its footsteps...Jerusalem the dance of the Zumba’

From the above quotation, it is clear that, Emmerson D Mnangagwa is going to take over power from a tyrannical ruler Robert G Mugabe a former Zimbabwean African National Union- Patriotic Front president (ZANU-PF). Prayzah is uttering about patriotism and social reform. According to Lazarus (1977:34), ‘Leaders come to neglect the very people who put them in power and incautiously become instruments of suppression on behalf of neo-colonialists.’ Instead of providing true leadership and guidance which is informed at every point by the ideal of the general welfare. There is need of responsible leader who is brave as a soldier (Mnangagwa).

In abridgment, it is crystal clear that, ‘*Kutonga Kwaro*’ 2017 by Jah Prayzah is the highest form of poetry and it provides a political retrocast and a forecast on Zimbabwean politics. The persona reveals Zimbabwe's bloodless coup, which took place in mid-November and brought to an end the 37-year rule of Robert Mugabe and at the same time he (Poet) brings to light how the current president Emmerson Dambudzo Mnangagwa hand over power from a former tyrannical ruler Mugabe. In a form of an allegory, the poem is attached to the Shona concept of ‘*Musha*’. All of the above was uncovered by the usage of vibrant poetic devices in the choruses and verses inside the poem ‘*Kutonga Kwaro*’ under exegesis in the above essay.

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